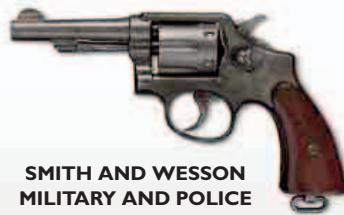




**SMITH AND WESSON
MODEL 3**

- 1852** Horace Smith and D. B. Wesson form their first partnership to produce a lever-action pistol, but this venture is not successful financially.
- 1856** Smith and Wesson form their second company to manufacture the Model 1 revolver.
- 1869** The Model 3 is introduced, selling in large numbers in Russia and elsewhere.
- 1875** An order from the US military leads to the



**SMITH AND WESSON
MILITARY AND POLICE**

- Schofield revolver, named for the locking system devised by Major George W. Schofield.
- 1898** When the Spanish-American War comes to an end, the US Army sells off many surplus Schofield revolvers, bringing these onto the civilian market.
- 1913** The company introduces its first center-fire semiautomatic pistol, the Model 1913.



**SMITH AND WESSON
MODEL 29**

- 1919** Smith and Wesson produce a variant of the successful Military and Police revolver with a baton extension for police use.
- 1955** The Model 29, chambered for the .44in Magnum cartridge, is launched.
- 1971** Clint Eastwood sports a Model 29 in the film *Dirty Harry*, hugely increasing its popularity.

tried to make similar firearms, and so White had to defend his patent in court. While the inventor was embroiled in his legal battle, Smith and Wesson developed the Model 2, a similar design but with a larger .32in caliber, which was more suitable for use in combat. The launch of the Model 2 in 1861 coincided with the start of the American Civil War, and Smith and Wesson found that there was a huge demand for the new revolver—by 1865, the two gunmakers were rich men. When the war ended, many soldiers took home their weapons, and soon Smith and Wesson firearms were in use all over the American West.

NEW MARKETS

After the Civil War, there was a steep decline in demand for firearms in the US. Models 1 and 2 had sold in hundreds of thousands, but in 1867, the company sold only 15 guns per month. Smith and Wesson began looking for



new markets. The company started to sell guns in large numbers overseas, notably to Russia, where the 1869 Model 3 proved successful. The company also sold the Model 3 to the US Cavalry, who used a modified version that was easier to load while riding. In 1874, Horace Smith retired, selling his share of the company to Wesson. In the late-19th century, Wesson produced guns that proved especially attractive in another key market—police forces. A number of police departments bought Smith and Wesson firearms, such as the .38in Safety Hammerless of the 1880s. In 1899, Wesson brought out the revolver that was the most enduring of all Smith and Wesson's products—the Military and Police revolver. Prized for its power, accuracy, and ease of loading, the Military and Police revolver sold in huge numbers to law-enforcement agencies all over the world. Modified in various ways,

▲ AUSTRALIAN POLICE

A police officer from Victoria, Australia, fires a .40in-caliber Smith and Wesson automatic pistol. Such weapons were chosen by his force in 2009 to replace older revolvers.

it remains in production and was used very widely until police and military units replaced it with semiautomatic weapons. It has been estimated that around 6 million Military and Police revolvers have been produced, and large numbers are still in use, including many by target shooters. This unique record easily makes it the 20th century's best-selling center-fire revolver. Smith and Wesson is also known for introducing Magnum cartridges to handguns. These cartridges are very powerful and generate a lot of recoil. Popular examples are the .357in and .44in cartridges. The company continues to build on its heritage, carrying its innovations into the 21st century.

